

Catholic Social Teaching (CST) is the area of Catholic theology that deals especially with the lived practice of the Catholic faith in society. As such, it is the moral framework within which the Church addresses societal issues. CST acknowledges the following concepts as being crucial to a precise understanding and application of its core themes: charity, human dignity, common good, and subsidiarity. These four concepts underlie the core themes of CST, namely: the dignity of every person; solidarity and common good; family life; subsidiarity and the proper role of government; property ownership; the dignity of work; colonialism and economic development; peace and disarmament; option for the poor; and care for the natural environment.

The Church proudly claims the phrase *Lex Orandi, Lex Credendi, Lex Vivendi*. As such, the Church's social doctrine should have a formative role in the life of the Catholic faithful through the liturgy. And it does. The Church's hymnody is a formative part of the liturgy which has allowed Catholic poets over the centuries to address matters of social doctrine. Indeed, all of the above concepts and themes can be seen in surprising level of detail in the following hymns: "Where Charity and Love Prevail," "Christ, Be our Light," and "O God of Earth and Altar."

"Charity is the theological virtue by which we love God above all things for His own sake, and our neighbors as ourselves for the love of God," (CCC 1822). Contrary to its popular use in contemporary society, charity is not simply almsgiving or philanthropy. Charity is the perfect, whole, self-giving love with which all humanity is called to love God and love each other. True charity is the overwhelming *agape* love which transcends all self interests and purifies human life. "The practices of all the virtues is animated and inspired by charity which 'binds everything together in perfect harmony'; it is the form of the virtues... it is the source and goal of their Christian practice," (CCC 1828).

It is in this light that Omer Westendorf's ["Where Charity and Love Prevail"](#) addresses the practice of Christian life:

1. Where charity and love prevail,
there God is ever found;
brought here together by Christ's love,
by love are we thus bound.

2. With grateful joy and holy fear
God's charity we learn;
let us with heart, and mind, and soul
now love Him in return.

3. Forgive we now each other's faults
as we our faults confess;
and let us love each other well
in Christian holiness.

4. Let strife among us be unknown;
let all contentions cease.
Be God's the glory that we seek;
be His our only peace.

5. Let us recall that in our midst
dwells Christ, God's only Son;
as members of His body joined,
we are, in Him, made one.

6. For love excludes no race or clan
that names the savior's name;
His family embraces all
whose Father is the same.

Written as a paraphrastic translation of the 8th century Latin text *Ubi Caritas* and set to the tune CHRISTIAN LOVE, an adaptation of the melody of the 4th century chant *Veni, Redemptor Omnium*, this ancient Maundy Thursday text addresses the familial love that Christians must have for those other Christians with whom they commune. This text has a lot to teach about CST. First, it articulates the concept of charity perfectly. The presence of charity is always the presence of God, who is Himself the fullness of charity. Those who gather in His

love are rightly bound together. “God is love, and those who abide in love abide in God, and God abides in them,” (I Jn. 4:16). The Christian community (the Church) is founded in charity, which inspires the faithful to mutual forgiveness, peace, and inclusion.

Verse 5 does a particularly good job articulating another crucial concept of CST: the dignity of the human person. When the Christian faithful gather as a community, they are to remember that “where two or three are gathered in [Christ’s] name, [Christ is] there among them,” (Mt. 18:20). The Church “the body of Christ” and the faithful are “individually members of it,” (I Cor. 12:27). Every human person is a vital member of Christ’s body, the Church. After all, “God created humankind in His image, in the image of God He created them,” (Gen. 1:27).

Once the Christian community acknowledges both a proper understanding of charity and the inherent dignity of every person, it is then able to recognize that it is a family. The immediate family – the father, mother, children – is the most basic structure of social life. This includes the Church. The Father provides for this family, holy mother Church nurtures her children, and those children are indeed “children of God,” (I Jn. 3:1). “Becoming a disciple of Jesus means accepting the invitation to belong to *God’s family*, to live in conformity with His way of life,” (CCC 2233). Verse 6 of the hymn details that God’s family of love is meant to embrace all people indiscriminate of race, heritage, or any other factor because, in every case, God remains the Father and creator of every human person.

The major goal of the charity of the Christian community portrayed in this hymn is to consider the common good. The common good, after all, is the goal of any family. As such, the family of God is invited to love each other well, forgive one another, put an end to their contentions and strife, and to seek the glory of God together. The people of God are bound together in charity – that complete and total love which transcends self interest – and are therefore called to pursue the best interest of one another, which is the common good.

Because of the self-giving pursuit of charity, the Church is compelled to serve those human persons outside of herself as well. “Love excludes no race nor clan,” and thus she gives herself to care for all those in need. This concept is detailed in Bernadette Farrell’s [“Christ, Be our Light”](#):

1. Longing for light,
we wait in darkness.
Longing for truth,
we turn to You.
Make us Your own,
Your holy people,
light for the world to see.

R/ Christ, be our light!
Shine in our hearts,
shine through the darkness.
Christ, be our light!
Shine in Your Church
gathered today.

2. Longing for peace,
our world is troubled.
Longing for hope,
many despair.
Your word alone
has pow’r to save us.
Make us Your living voice.

R/
3. Longing for food,
many are hungry.
Longing for water,
many still thirst.
Make us Your bread,
broken for others,
shared until all are fed. R/

4. Longing for shelter,
many are homeless.
Longing for warmth,
many are cold.
Make us Your building,
sheltering others,
walls made of living stone.

R/
5. Many the gifts,
many the people,
many the hearts
that yearn to belong.
Let us be servants
to one another,
signs of Your kingdom
come. R/

Christ is Himself the “light of the world,” (Jn. 8:12). Quoting from Isaiah, Jesus once said, “the people who sat in darkness have seen a great light, and for those who sat in the region and shadow of death light has dawned,” (Mt. 4:16). Combining these two images, it is apparent that Christ came as the light of the world to dispel the darkness of sin and to bring hope to the hopeless. Matthew’s narrative continued, however, “From that time Jesus began to proclaim, ‘Repent, for the kingdom of heaven has come near,’” (Mt. 4:17). Christ established a kingdom – the Church. In another point in his Gospel, Matthew recounts that Christ said of the Church, “You are the light of the world... let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father in heaven,” (Mt. 5:14, 16). All of these ideas together point to the fact that the mission of the Church is to be Christ’s light present in the world by bringing hope to the hopeless and by doing good works.

This idea of the Church’s mission is repeated in this hymn’s refrain. Christ is the light of the Church, and the Church is a conduit of that light for the rest of the world. Creation longs for “light,” that is, truth, peace, hope, food, water, shelter, and warmth. The Church knows her mission is to carry out this light for the world and thus, in each verse, she asks Christ to make her more perfectly capable of fulfilling her obligation.

The Church recognizes that she is to give a preferential option for the poor. “[T]hose who are oppressed by poverty are the object of a *preferential love* on the part of the Church which, since her origin and in spite of the failings of many of her members, has not ceased to work for their relief, defense, and liberation through numerous works of charity which remain indispensable always and everywhere,” (CCC 2448). This preferential option manifests itself in many of the ways seen in the hymn: by being the living voice for peace in this troubled world; by giving of itself to share to those who have food insecurity; by being the “living stones” of the Church, both able to provide physical housing for the homeless, and able to be a welcoming community for the lonely.

The Church, in battling poverty, also battles the causes of poverty. It is her duty to protect against the injustices of oppression at every level. Economic, environmental, and other systemic factors have disadvantaged the poor throughout human history, and so the Church must do her best to minimize the effects of these factors. However, she can not do that by her own power. CST recognizes the essentiality of civil authorities in fighting against systemic injustices. This idea is thoughtfully expressed in G. K. Chesterton’s [“O God of Earth and Altar”](#):

1. O God of earth and altar,
bow down and hear our cry;
our earthly rulers falter,
our people drift and die;
the walls of gold entomb us,
the swords of scorn divide,
take not Thy thunder from us,
but take away our pride.

2. From all that terror teaches,
from lies of tongue and pen,
from all the easy speeches
that comfort cruel men,

from sale and profanation
of honor and the sword,
from sleep and from damnation,
deliver us, good Lord!

3. Tie in a living tether
the prince and priest and thrall,
bind all our lives together,
smite us and save us all;
in ire and exultation
aflame with faith, and free,
lift up a living nation,
a single sword to Thee.

Arranged to the inspiring tune KING'S LYNN by Ralph Vaughan Williams, this well-crafted text identifies the right perception that the Christian faithful should have of their civil authorities. The opening of the hymn is reminiscent of Psalm 86, where David prays, "Incline your ear, O Lord, and answer me, for I am poor and needy." Likewise, the opening lines ask God to listen as the Church petitions Him for the rest of the hymn.

"To promote the participation of the greatest number in the life of a society, the creation of voluntary associations and institutions must be encouraged 'on both national and international levels, which relate to economic and social goals, to cultural and recreational activities, to sport, to various professions, and to political affairs,'" (CCC 1882). This is the concept of socialization: each organization is composed of human persons working toward a goal to promote a common good. Governments are organizations of people working for the common good of their citizens by protecting and defending their rights. Businesses are organizations of people working for the common good of their customers and employees by providing goods and services through the economy. Recreational organizations, sports teams, and the like are composed of people working for the common good of the public by providing entertainment. Even the Church is an organization of people working for the common good of all creation.

The hymn recognizes the potential dangers of socialization whereby these organizations forget their vocation of tending to the common good. Verse 1 describes the way that organizations sin against their callings. "Our earthly rulers falter, our people drift and die." It is chilling to hear the failures of this world expressed in such a way. CST accounts for this. "Socialization also presents dangers. Excessive intervention by the state can threaten personal freedom and initiative. The teaching of the Church has elaborated the principle of *subsidiarity*, according to which 'a community of higher order should not interfere in the internal life of a community of a lower order, depriving the latter of its functions, but rather should support it in case of need and help to co-ordinate its activity with the activities of the rest of society, always with a view to the common good,' (CCC 1883). These associations are only good and effective if their leaders properly serve the people they represent.

The hymn confronts systemic issues, criticizing the excesses of wealth ("the walls of gold entomb us") and the divisions sown by pride and scorn. These lines reflect CST's emphasis on social justice and solidarity, urging the faithful to unite against societal inequalities and call for humility. The acknowledgment of rulers' shortcomings invites a sense of collective responsibility to ensure that civil authorities act with justice and integrity.

Thus, verse 2 asks for deliverance from all societal evils – from slanders, from politicians who distort the truth, from the sale and profanation of honor, from unjust warfare, and even from our unconscious participation in these evils. Verse 3 therefore calls everyone to recognize the interconnectedness of socialization. The "prince" (the government), the "priest" (the Church), and the "thrall" (the working class) are asked to be bound together so that they may each seek the common good in their own ways without harmfully encroaching on the work of another. When lines are inevitably crossed, the victims of lower orders of society (such as the lowly "thrall") reserve the right to protest the encroaching higher orders in order to promote the dignity of their own work.

The hymn concludes with a stirring call to unity, stating that all should be bound into one "living nation, aflame with faith." This is the ultimate aspiration of CST (indeed it is the ultimate mission of the Church): for all humanity to be united as the kingdom of God, committed to providing to the common good of all with respect to their human dignity through charity.